frank discussions of economic issues, which in today's world extend more and more across international boundaries.

One issue that always came up was trade protectionism.

The principles underlying my support of free and fair trade are pretty simple: The operation of the free market is based on the concept that people make a product or produce a service which they hope other people will want to buy. Then, in millions of separate decisions, consumers choose which products and services they want to buy, when they are going to buy them, and how much they are willing to pay for them. Free competition and the law of supply and demand determine the prices and the winners and the losers in the competition. If customers stop buying an enterprise's product because it doesn't match the standards of another product, it's up to that enterprise to improve the product or it will lose its ability to compete.

If consumers in one country are going to be able to buy goods produced in another country, their nation must have income generated by the sale of goods and services abroad. We can't say to them, "We want to sell you something that we make, but don't send us your products."

For the free market to work, everyone has to compete on an equal footing. That way, prices and demand go up or down based on the free choices of people; there are winners and losers under the system of free competition, but consumers are the ultimate benefactors. Free competition produces better products and lower prices. However, when governments fix or control the price, impose quotas, subsidize manufacturers or farmers, or otherwise intervene in the free market with artificial restrictions, it isn't free and it won't work as it is supposed to work.

At all eight of the economic summits I attended, I tried to preach the virtues of free trade. In principle, the other leaders expressed a similar view, and denounced the trade